

Aruna Parandhama

As an educator who teaches the first class of the day, I am often entrusted with a daunting task: keeping a 7:00 am classroom awake and engaged. My students are largely pursuing professional qualifications in Commerce and Business Management, and many view subjects outside their immediate career goals as peripheral, resulting in a display of restlessness in class. Over the years, I have come to see restlessness among students not as a barrier to learning but as an invitation to rethink how learning happens. Students who appear distracted, impatient, or unwilling to sit through a lecture are often capable of remarkable intellectual engagement when given the opportunity to participate, rather than merely listen.

**Willing to question**  
One particular episode unfolded in a General English course titled Contemporary Debates I: Negotiating Identities, offered to second-year undergraduate students. It introduces learners to questions surrounding nationhood, caste, gender, multiculturalism, and other forces that shape contemporary society through literary texts and emerging forms of expression. I chose to discuss the idea of bor-



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## Don't teach, steer

With Teachers' Day just past, an educator reflects on how restlessness among students is not a barrier to learning but an invitation to rethink how learning happens

ders through the poem Nation of Birds by K. Satchidanandan, which imagines a world in which birds move freely across territories, unconstrained by the borders that humans create and defend. The students understood the poem's central argument almost immediately. While my intention was to ensure

that they agreed with the poet, I invited them to challenge him.

If there is one thing that adolescents are rarely short of, it is the willingness to question received wisdom. Educational psychologists like Eric Erikson and Jean Piaget have long noted that adolescence is a period marked by identi-

ty formation, scepticism, and the testing of boundaries. Rather than viewing these tendencies as disruptions to classroom order, I wanted to harness them.

I divided the class into two teams. One would defend the idea that national borders remain necessary; the other would argue against it. The only

rule was that every claim had to be challenged. Students were encouraged to use their phones to access information, verify facts, and strengthen their arguments. To make the exercise more engaging, I gave it a dramatic title: Sink or Float. The objective was to keep your team's argument afloat while sinking the

opposing side's position. What followed was one of the most animated discussions of the semester.

**Wide-ranging discussion**  
Arguments emerged from all corners of the classroom. Some students insisted that borders are essential for security, governance, and national identity. Others questioned whether borders continue to serve their intended purpose in an increasingly interconnected world. One student remarked, "We are not birds; we cannot simply live without systems and structures." Another student challenged the assumption that existing political arrangements are immutable merely because they have existed for a long time.

The discussion moved swiftly from literature to history, politics, migration, and economics. Examples ranged from contemporary debates surrounding migration across the United States-Mexico border to questions of indigeneity, ancestry, and belonging. At that point, my role had ceased as a lecturer delivering content. I became a facilitator. I steered the discussion, introduced alternative perspectives, corrected facts, and encouraged students to support their claims with evidence. Whenever an argument became overtly rhetorical or speculative, I pushed the stu-

dents to substantiate it. The learning emerged not only from my explanations but also from their engagement with one another. They were learning to construct tightly structured arguments, evaluate evidence, identify assumptions, and respectfully challenge opposing viewpoints. These are skills that extend far beyond the study of literature.

The students of today inhabit a world vastly different from the one in which we were raised. They are accustomed to interaction, immediacy, and participation. This does not mean that educators must constantly entertain students or transform every lesson into a spectacle. It means, however, that we must recognise the potential embedded within their energy.

That morning, I was reminded that meaningful learning often occurs when teachers relinquish a measure of control and allow students to take ownership of inquiry. Perhaps, then, the task of the contemporary educator is not simply to teach a restless class. It is to steer one. For within that restlessness lies the possibility of curiosity, critical thinking, and the kind of democratic dialogue that education, at its best, seeks to nurture.

The writer is an Assistant Professor, Department of English, St Joseph's College of Commerce, Bengaluru.

### SCHOLARSHIPS

#### Buddy4Study Gati Shakti Scholarship

An initiative by Buddy4Study.  
**Eligibility:** Indian students from Classes 9-12 or pursuing vocational, ITI, Polytechnic, UG or PG courses who are children/wards of heavy/light commercial vehicle drivers and have got minimum 60% in the previous class/semester and have an annual family income not exceeding ₹800,000.  
**Rewards:** Up to ₹30,000.  
**Application:** Online  
**Deadline:** September 30  
www.b4s.in/edge/B4SGSI

#### Reliance Foundation Postgraduate Scholarships

Offered by the Reliance Foundation.  
**Eligibility:** Resident Indian citizens enrolled in the first-year of full-time PG programmes in Engineering, Technology, Energy and Life Sciences and have secured 550 to 1,000 in the GATE exam, or have a CGPA of 7.5 or above in their UG studies.  
**Rewards:** Up to ₹600,000 for the duration of the course of study  
**Application:** Online  
**Deadline:** October 5  
www.b4s.in/edge/RFSI5

#### Swami Dayanand India Scholarship

Offered by the Swami Dayanand Education Foundation.  
**Eligibility:** First-year students in full-time UG professional degree programmes (Engineering, Medicine, Dentistry, Nursing, Pharmacy, Architecture, and Veterinary Science) in India with 80% in Class 12 and an annual family income of ₹1,200,000 lakh or less.  
**Rewards:** Up to ₹50,000 per year.  
**Application:** Online  
**Deadline:** October 31  
www.b4s.in/edge/SDIS2

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com



OFF THE EDGE  
Nandini Raman

**I am doing a Master's in Economics and confident about getting a corporate job. But I am not sure whether this is what I want. I am passionate about studying but do not have the GPA to get into the best M.Phil. and Ph.D. programmes abroad. Civil Services is one option. How can I narrow my interest down to one path? Aadya**

Dear Aadya,  
Where does your interest truly lie, and what would make you happiest? The corporate route offers strong financial rewards, but the work can be narrow, execution-driven and tied to business cycles. Civil Services can be demanding until you clear the exam, but it can be deeply fulfilling if you enjoy working on policy at a macro level. However, the low selection ratio makes it a high-risk path.  
Foreign universities often value quantitative ability and meaningful research experience more than grades. Consider working as a Research Assistant for a couple of years before applying for a Ph.D. Explore research openings at global universities that offer remote positions or visa sponsorship. A strong Letter of Recommendation can significantly strengthen your application. Another option is the Indian Economic Service (IES), a UPSC examination for Economics postgraduates.  
Your immediate priority should be to identify a path that genuinely interests you, matches your strengths, and that you can commit to wholeheartedly.

**I have done B.E. Civil Engineering graduate and a Master's in Urban**

## Stay committed

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

**Planning. I am working as a town planner with the state government (Group A). What courses can I pursue to enhance my practical skills? Is there a more prestigious central government or public sector job in urban planning that I can prepare for? Sehaj**

Dear Sehaj,  
At this stage, specialised certifications in technical and data-driven areas could add value to your profile. The Indian Institute of Remote Sensing (IIRS-ISRO) offers courses in GIS applications for urban and regional planning. Consider executive modules from the Institute of Urban Transport (IUT), under MoHUA, in Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) and mobility. A PMP or PRINCE2 certification can strengthen skills in budgeting, risk management and planning. For sustainable urban development, LEED Green Associate or GRIHA Certified Professional could be valuable.  
If you are considering government or public-sector roles, explore UPSC direct recruitment and deputation opportunities, as well as openings in PSUs. Look towards strategy and policy roles with the National Institute of Urban Affairs (NIUA) or multilateral institutions such as the World Bank, Asian Development Bank and Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank. The key is to choose opportunities that build on your experience and align with your goals.

**I finished PG in Political Science in 2025. I don't have the skills to land a job and am low on self**

**confidence. I have taken the UGC-NET. I want to appear for UPSC and am preparing for the SSC but paper leaks and lack of trust in institutions has caused further alienation. What can I do? Akansha**

Dear Akansha,  
Your M.A. in Political Science has given you valuable skills such as understanding governance and public policy, analysing complex information, and communicating ideas clearly. You do not lack skills; you need to showcase them. Consider public policy and think tanks. Organisations such as Centre for Policy Research (CPR), Observer Research Foundation (ORF), PRS Legislative Research, and J-PAL South Asia recruit research assistants and interns. Political consulting is another growing field, with roles in constituency research, digital campaigns and voter analysis. You could explore firms such as I-PAC and DesignBoxed. Ed-tech companies also hire Political Science graduates as subject experts, content developers and evaluators.  
For now, step away from the competitive-exam cycle if it is draining you. Start with two focused hours a day: pick a current policy issue, write a 600-word analysis, and publish it on LinkedIn or Medium. Explore legislative opportunities such as the LAMP Fellowship or state-level fellowships. Rebuild your confidence while turning your academic skills into a visible portfolio.

**I have completed Class 12 (PCB) but am interested in journalism and mass communication. Should I pursue a Bachelor's degree in Journalism or Mass**

### Communication? Which colleges or institutes should I focus on? Pratibha

Dear Pratibha,  
A B.A. in Journalism and Mass Communication or B.A. Mass Media offers practical training in television, print, radio, digital media, advertising and PR, making it suitable if you want hands-on skills and early industry exposure. Alternatively, a B.A. (Hons) in English, Psychology, Political Science or Sociology can help you develop critical thinking, contextual writing and subject expertise. A Liberal Arts degree offers broader exposure to the Humanities, Social Sciences, and Natural Sciences. This can be followed by a specialised PG Diploma in Journalism.

Whichever you choose, focus on building a strong portfolio alongside your academics. Develop digital skills such as video editing, Adobe Premiere Pro or DaVinci Resolve, and graphic design using Canva or Photoshop. Media organisations value reporters who can understand statistics, interpret scientific research, and explain complex information clearly. Start writing regularly: summarise current events, maintain a blog or contribute to local or educational publications.

For undergraduate media studies, explore institutions such as Delhi University, Symbiosis, Christ University, St. Xavier's College, Loyola College, Madras Christian College and SRM Institute of Science and Technology. Check current admission requirements, including CUET-UG where applicable.

**Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.**

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

## Campuses that care

How a college's design contributes to student wellbeing



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Amit Kundal

Student well-being has become one of the most talked-about issues in higher education. Rising levels of anxiety, loneliness, and digital dependence have prompted universities around the world to rethink not just how they support students, but also the environments in which students live and learn. While institutions are investing in counselling services, peer support networks, and wellness programmes that address real pressures that students face, an important question often goes unasked: what role does the campus environment itself play in shaping how students feel, connect, and grow?

Research in higher education has consistently shown that a strong sense of belonging is closely associated with students' academic success, persistence, and psychological well-being. Belonging is shaped not only by programmes and policies, but also by the environments in which students learn every day. Well-being should not be an intervention layered onto campus life but embedded into its de-

sign. Interventions such as counselling and other support services often respond to problems after they emerge. Designing campuses that foster connection, curiosity, creativity, and belonging offers an opportunity to prevent many of these challenges before they take root.

**Deliberate choice**  
Design in the context of education is not about beautiful buildings or landscaped campuses. Design, in its truest sense, is about intention: the deliberate choices that shape how people move through a space, how they encounter each other, where they pause, where they feel they belong. Ask most students about the moments that shaped them most in college, and rarely will they point to a lecture.

More often, it is a conversation that happened after class, a debate that spilt into a courtyard, a collaborative project that brought together people from completely different disciplines, or a quiet afternoon spent thinking beneath a tree. These moments do not happen by accident. They happen because a space made them possible.

Open commons, shaded

walkways, informal lounges, and outdoor learning areas are not secondary features of a campus. They are where connection, belonging, and genuine self-discovery take place. When students from different disciplines are brought together in shared spaces, they encounter ways of thinking that challenge their own. They develop empathy, intellectual curiosity, and the ability to collaborate across differences. Hence, designing for these encounters should be an intentional choice.

Studios, maker spaces, performance venues, rehearsal rooms, and exhibition areas are often viewed as specialised facilities serving students in Arts and Design programmes. But creative spaces are environments where students experiment without the pressure of being right, where they express what they cannot always put into words, where they process difficult experiences, take risks, and discover capabilities they didn't know they had. In this sense, creative infrastructure is well-being infrastructure. Institutions that invest in such spaces are building environments where students develop re-

silience, voice, and a sense of agency over their own experience.

Inclusion

None of this matters if these spaces exclude the very students they are meant to serve. Inclusion in campus design goes well beyond ramps and compliance checkboxes. It is about creating environments where students from different backgrounds, abilities, and identities feel genuinely welcomed and able to participate fully in campus life. A space that makes certain students feel invisible cannot contribute to their well-being, no matter how thoughtfully it has been designed for everyone else. Accessibility, cultural responsiveness, and flexibility must be built in from the beginning, not retrofitted as an afterthought.

Around the world, leading universities are increasingly recognising that belonging, collaboration, and informal learning are not accidental outcomes but intentional design objectives. The conversation is gradually shifting from building campuses that simply accommodate students to creating environments that actively help them flourish.

Universities have long devoted enormous attention to designing curricula. The next frontier is designing the environments in which those curricula come alive. Campus design is not simply an architectural or facilities decision; it is an educational one. Every pathway, commons, studio, and gathering space communicates what an institution values and shapes how students connect, learn, and see themselves. In many ways, this hidden curriculum of campus design may influence students as profoundly as the formal curriculum itself.

The writer is Dean, Faculty of Design, Art and Performance, FLAME University.

Ramakrishnan Raman

In the past, guidance for youngsters came from grandparents, teachers, and elders. Today, however, students are navigating a world that is changing faster than before. The most well-meaning guidance, if outdated or too narrow, can only take a young person so far. It is time to think of not replacing existing mentors but expanding the circle.

Shared knowledge

The concept of a personal board of mentors is simple in principle. Just as a well-governed institution relies on a board with diverse expertise (strategic, financial, ethical, operational), a student too can benefit enormously from a trusted circle of individuals who collectively guide their academic,

professional, and personal growth.

A generation ago, career choices were relatively finite – Engineering, Medicine, Law, the Civil Services, or Commerce. Today, a young person may be seriously considering careers in Artificial Intelligence, Data Science, Sustainable Development, Digital Entrepreneurship, Sports Management, or Public Policy. These are not fringe choices; they are the emerging spine of the global economy. The knowledge required to guide a student meaningfully through even one of these paths is highly specialised and cannot be done by a single individual. This is simply the reality of a rapidly evolving world.

Teachers remain the foundation of every student’s intellectual and moral formation. What is needed is something to complement it. An in-



# The right guides

Why every student needs a personal board of mentors

dustry professional can offer the texture of real-world experience and an honest account of what a career actually demands. A senior student or alumnus, having recently navigated the same transitions, can speak to immediate anxieties – interviews, entrance tests, early career decisions – with a credibility that comes only from lived proximity. An entrepreneur can encourage calculated risk and re-frame setbacks as learning. A family elder offers what no professional network can replace: wisdom rooted in values and long-term perspective. Together, these mentors form something far more powerful than the sum of their individual contributions.

There is also an equity dimension that cannot be ignored. Students from metropolitan cities often arrive at university

already embedded in professional networks, alumni communities, family connections, and prior internships. Many from smaller towns and first-generation learner families do not. This is not a failure of ambition. It is a structural gap and a personal board of mentors, when built deliberately, can begin to close it.

Starting point

So where does a student begin? Start small and start intentionally. Identify four to five people with complementary strengths: a teacher who knows your abilities well, a professional in your field of interest, an alumnus who has recently walked the path ahead, a peer who keeps you accountable, and a family elder whose judgment you trust. Approach each with sincerity and a specific question rather than a

vague request. Most people, when approached respectfully, are far more willing to help than students expect. These relationships do not need to be formal. They need to be genuine.

Building this circle is not a one-time task. It is a habit that the most purposeful students cultivate early and tend to carefully through their academic years and beyond. Education is the cultivation of capability, confidence, and character. No single classroom, however excellent, can complete that journey alone. The students who go furthest in life are rarely those who have the most talent. They are those who had the right people around them, at the right time.

The writer is Vice Chancellor, Symbiosis International Deemed University.

## Find a balance

When it comes to Artificial Intelligence, the benefits and costs of the technology increase exponentially



THINK  
Aruna Sankaranarayanan

As AI continues to leapfrog day by day, educators are grappling with the types of assignments and assessments to give students. Due to rampant cheating using AI, many universities are shifting from long-form research papers to proctored in-person, handwritten exams. Oral exams or viva voces are also making a comeback so professors can judge whether students actually understand a topic.

At the same time, some professors encourage students to use AI for aspects of an assignment, especially when they feel it can enhance student learning.

Whether AI promotes or hinders learning depends on how it is used. Used intelligently and responsibly, AI can supercharge learning. Used indiscriminately or with the sole purpose of gaming the system, it can seriously impair human potential. Knowing the difference between cognitive offloading and cognitive surrender can help people use AI with discernment.

Impact of technology

In April, *The Economist’s* column Bartleby explained that calculators didn’t make humans “innumerate”. On the contrary, they actually helped individuals enhance their mathematical capabilities. As people didn’t have to waste time and mental effort

on tedious calculations, they could focus more on reasoning and problem solving.

Similarly, GPS makes us more efficient, as we don’t have to stop and pore over maps or ask strangers for directions. Further, we can also take routes that bypass traffic snarls.

But Bartleby notes that there are costs associated with both technologies. Researchers have found that, if calculators are programmed to give incorrect answers, few students are aware of the inaccuracies. More troubling, a subset of them fail to notice glaringly obvious mistakes. Likewise, an over-reliance on GPS is linked with poorer spatial memory.

When it comes to AI, both the benefits and costs of the technology increase exponentially. The term “cognitive surrender”, coined by Steven Shaw and Gideon Nave, describes what happens when we completely outsource our thinking. In one study, the experimental group were asked to answer challenging questions using AI, whereas the control group did the task without assistance. The researchers also deliberately introduced errors into the bot’s answers.

When no mistakes were introduced, the group using AI performed better than the control group. However, when AI generated wrong answers, the control group did better. So, when people use AI, they don’t necessarily use their critical faculties.

Impact on creativity

When we interact with AI, we need to be mind-

ful of what aspects of a task we are outsourcing. If we’re becoming more efficient and gaining knowledge and skills, we stand to gain immensely. Many bots have a learning mode that facilitates problem-solving and refines your skills. On the other hand, depending on AI to think for us puts us at grave risk because AI can be wrong and even fabricate information. In an article in *The New York Times* (June 29), Noam Scheiber writes that research found that managers were more negligent when checking for errors in documents created by AI. However, others who thought that a human had produced the documents were more thorough and spotted the mistakes. This shows that, while we expect humans to make mistakes, most people think AI is infallible.

What happens when everyone depends on AI for thinking? Scheiber writes that some issues may not be noticeable at the “individual level” but may emerge collectively and over time. Suppose scientists begin to rely on AI to guide them through every step of the scientific process in their respective domains, from deciding what to study to how. Gradually, all scientists in a field may start thinking alike, hindering creativity in various disciplines. Even as AI gets more competent and potent, the need for human critical reasoning, discernment and judgment is only going to get stronger.

The author is Visiting Faculty, School of Education at Azim Premji University and co-author of *Bee-witched*.

M. Venu Gopala Rao

Two numbers frame the question. In December 2025, NITI Aayog recorded that for every international student who came to India in 2024, 28 Indian students went abroad. Indian families spent close to ₹2.9 lakh crore on overseas education that year.

Read alone, that sounds like an indictment. Read alongside everything else now happening, it looks more like an unfinished agenda. India runs the third largest higher education system on earth: over 56,000 institutions and four crore students. Fifty-four Indian universities featured in the QS World University Rankings 2026, up from 11 a decade ago, making India the fourth most represented nation and the fastest riser among G20 economies.

The gaps

The constraint, then, is not capacity. Nor is it talent. Indian students compete successfully at the highest levels of every global institution that admits them. As Joint Director of the Indo-German Institute of Advanced Technology, a bilateral initiative with German partners, I spent two years in an institution designed around industry collaboration and international standards of execution.

With INWEnt Germany

Vipin Kumar Tripathi

India’s current Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER), according to the All India Survey of Higher Education for 2023-24 is 30%. What we require is a transformation in university and college education.

Higher education should be available to every student who leaves school. This requires building on existing infrastructure and changing campuses into centres of free-thinking and creativity.

As of June 2025, India had 1,338 Universities (Central, state and private), 52,081 colleges, and around 165 Institutes of National Importance. While the teacher: student ratio is 1:26, close to 30% of teaching positions in central universities and institutions such as the IITs and NITs remain vacant.

Education receives just about 4% of the allocation in the GDP and allocation for research is around 0.66%. Academic institutions barely get any money for research. In contrast, countries like China, the U.S., and the U.K. spend a much higher percentage of their GDP on research.

Exam reform

Apart from increasing the budgetary expenditure on



## A maturity curve

Why Indian higher education requires institutional architecture

and the University of Bonn, we delivered 75 industry training programmes and built a consultancy practice that earned real revenue. The engineers were Indian. The talent was Indian. What the partnership contributed was process discipline, industry embedded as a design principle rather than an afterthought, and benchmarking against international rather than local standards.

The constraint, therefore, is institutional architecture. Over several years, I have tried to map the gaps between a typical Indian university and well-known

foreign ones. Seven recur.

One, their faculty are knowledge creators running funded laboratories; ours have been teachers carrying heavy timetables, with research often undertaken to satisfy an accreditation criterion rather than to answer a question. A paper written for an API score and one written from genuine inquiry look identical on a spreadsheet but are entirely different.

Two, their curricula move every semester, co-designed with industry; ours revise slowly and remain exam-driven. A syllabus on a three-year cycle cannot serve industries

that reorganise annually.

Three, their promotions follow output; ours follow seniority.

Four, their campuses carry venture funding and treat failure as instruction, while our innovation cells have too often existed on paper, with entrepreneurship earning no academic credit.

Five, their students argue, build and investigate; ours are still trained to memorise.

Six, their industry relationships take the form of endowed chairs and joint laboratories; ours remain confined to the placement cell, with industry treated as recruiter rather than partner.

Seven, their international offices carry staff, budgets, and targets. Too many of ours exist only in the organogram.

Making the transition

Beneath all sits one cause: governance maturity. Most Indian private universities are young institutions built by founders with genuine vision. The question is: how does an institution then move from an entrepreneurial phase to an institutional one, where systems run independently of any individual and planning extends beyond the next admission season? Universities the world over have made that transition. It is a maturity curve rather than a failing, and a growing number of Indian man-



## An urgent need

What can be done to reform higher education in India

education and research, there are other changes that need to be brought in. The current practice of centralised entrance exams for professional courses is problematic. These can be decentralised, and the basis of admission can be the results of the board exams and an aptitude test held by the institution.

For admission to prestigious institutions, a zonal aptitude test can be held, but with significant weightage given to board exam results. Provision must be made for students from deprived and marginalised

backgrounds.

The centralised entrance exams have led to the expansion of expensive coaching centres and unnecessary stress for students. Of late, the issue of paper leaks has been a talking point. In the last five years, 60 major exams have been cancelled due to question papers being leaked.

Institutional change

Students and teachers are the core of education. They deserve full freedom and respect and must be represented in executive

and academic councils. The performance of the VCs and principals can be assessed annually with participation from teachers and students. Faculty appointments must take into account recommendations from the department. Curbs in free thinking need to be removed and open discussions on national and international issues should be encouraged. Sectarianism should not have a place on campuses.

Course modernization should be conducted in consultation with teachers and feedback from stu-

dents. Students from all streams should have access to technical courses and the government should provide support for this.

Research should be encouraged and students should be given access to journals and publications. Evaluations and assessment practices should be transparent.

Reduce the gap

There is a great difference in the cost of education between government and private institutions and in the education offered. There must be an attempt to create a level playing field, where there is not much difference between institutions. Elite institutions and national labs should support other institutions to strengthen their teaching and research. Increasing the number of fellowships offered by the UGC, CSIR, and other bodies would help, as would ensuring that every university has a specific quota allocated to it. With industry-academia collaborations on the rise, the former can be encouraged to use CSR allocations to fund research in higher education institutions.

*Views expressed are personal.*

The author is a retired professor of Physics from IIT-Delhi.

